

Nigamanth P

nigamanth.p@thehindu.co.in

The main event of UFC 319 was billed as a clash of titans, but what unfolded was a masterclass in strategic domination.

The highly anticipated bout between Dricus Du Plessis and Khamzat Chimaev was a stark reminder that in mixed martial arts, patience and positioning can neutralise even the most versatile of champions. From the opening bell, the narrative was set: this would be a wrestling match, and Chimaev was the undeniable architect.

In the first round, 'Borz' wasted no time, dragging Du Plessis to the mat within 15 seconds. This wasn't just a takedown — it was a statement.

Chimaev's grappling, an extraordinary mix of speed, technical precision, and brute power, smothered Du Plessis's offence. Takedowns are Chimaev's signature, and his numbers back it up: 26 successful takedowns and a flawless defensive record.

For the first three rounds, the pattern was suffocating. Du Plessis, usually defined by pace and unorthodox striking, was reduced to survival mode, constantly fending off takedowns and unable to unleash his heavy hands.

Although Du Plessis showed grit in the later rounds, repelling some advances, the damage was irreversible. The unanimous decision for Chimaev was never in doubt, with all three judges siding with him. The victory crowned Chimaev the new middleweight champion and reinforced his standing as one of the most fearsome grapplers in MMA history.

Yet the true story emerged after the final bell. In a sport often fuelled by animosity, mutual respect took centre stage. Chimaev was seen encouraging Du Plessis's corner mid-fight, and post-bout, both fighters exchanged words of admiration. Du Plessis later wrote on social media: "I have absolutely no excuses for my

performance; I was beaten by a better fighter on the night. Congratulations to my opponent, and thank you for the honour of sharing the Octagon with you."

That spirit of sportsmanship offered a dignified conclusion to a one-sided but compelling title fight.

On a new path

For Aljamain Sterling, the former bantamweight champion, stepping into the featherweight division was a calculated gamble. At UFC Fight Night, his performance against Brian Ortega showed both the wisdom of the move and his determination to reclaim elite status. Sterling claimed a dominant unanimous decision, with all three scorecards reading 50-45 — a masterclass in controlled aggression and tactical precision.

His strategy revolved around a sharp, persistent jab. More than just a range-finder, it dictated distance, disrupted Ortega's rhythm, and created openings for combinations. Sterling's footwork complemented his striking, allowing him to land cleanly before slipping out of range and denying Ortega the chance to build sustained offence.

This measured approach defied expectations of a slugfest but underlined Sterling's evolution. He no longer needed to prove himself in a brawl; he could dismantle an opponent with patience and precision.

After losing his bantamweight crown, Sterling now faces the uphill climb of a new division. Defeating a top-tier opponent like Ortega is a crucial first step, cementing his place in the featherweight rankings and sending a clear message: the 'Funk Master' is back, and he is a serious contender.

Precision strike: Aljamain Sterling (left) lands a stinging shot on Brian Ortega in their 153-pound catchweight showdown at UFC Fight Night in Shanghai.

